HOW DO WE SAVE OUR BIRDS?

Even as a majority of the bird species decline in India, 217 others have reported a stable or rising population in the past eight years and could hold a valuable lesson on what we can do to protect our birds. For any conservation project to be successful, though, there are some essential parameters. Chavan, who has more than two decades of experience in the field, lists them thus: "The first thing to do is to gather scientific evidence. Ecological systems are very complex and chaotic, and we need data (to understand them better). The second thing is not to be preachy or authoritarian about it. You are dealing with a lot of humans who interact with birds, you don't tell them what to do, rather you have a dialogue with them." Finally, he advocates, you need a concrete plan of action, customised to local needs. "A lot of conservation has sadly become templatised—you do a school education programme, a research programme, a training programme. It doesn't always work. You must design your interventions carefully, using the first two steps," he says.

SAVING BIRDS, THEREFORE, has to be a mix of an enabling environment, research and citizen science. To protect the country's bird life, the MoEFCC had on February 3, 2020, introduced a 10-year plan for bird conservation. Its aim was to protect endangered species, start recovery programmes of critically-endangered birds, protect birds in urban areas, and preserve their habitats. One interesting approach was to start conserving areas of avian importance outside of protected zones. India has a network of 1,014 protected areas (PAs), which includes national parks, wildlife sanctuaries, community and conservation reserves. The government had designated 554 sites outside of these zones as Important Bird & Biodiversity Areas (IBAs); 506 of these have globally threatened bird species.

Two years earlier, the ministry had also unveiled the National Action Plan for Conservation of Migratory Birds (2018-2023), meant for birds along the Central Asian Flyway. India's National Wildlife Action Plan (2017-2031) also incorporates guidelines for the protection of birds and their habitats. A few government-individual efforts have already yielded encouraging results. In Madhya Pradesh, for instance, voluntary agency Bhopal Birds commenced a community-based programme to protect the Sarus crane in 2014. The programme, in which the Wildlife Trust of India (WTI) and the MP forest department were partners as well, involved the appointment of Sarus Mitras, or friends of cranes, around the Ramsar site of Upper Lake in Bhopal. "In 2014, only 12 Saruses were reported in the Bhoj Wetland Area around Upper Lake. That had increased to 312 by 2021," says Mohammed Khalique, founder of Bhopal Birds. The bird has also seen a revival in Uttar

THE HARDY BIRDS

Healthy both in abundance and in distribution, a few endemic bird species are exhibiting a rising trend in the past three decades

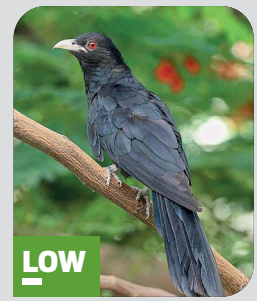


SHUTTERSTOCK

INDIAN PEAFOWL

Pavo cristalus

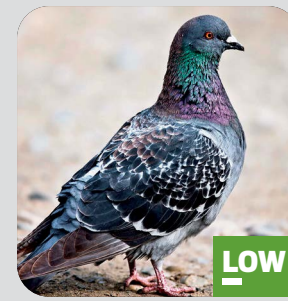
A rapidly increasing species, it is expanding into new areas such as the rainforests in the Western Ghats and the high Himalayas. It is now found in every district of Kerala where once it was extremely rare. The exact reasons are unclear, but their proliferation owes to protection by law and through religious-cultural beliefs. However, rising uncontrolled numbers can have a negative impact on snakes and crops.



ASIAN KOEL

Eudynamys scolopaceus

It has increased by almost 75 per cent compared to its pre-2000 baseline. No one knows why, but fruit-eating birds in general are doing well



ROCK PIGEON

Columba livia

It has successfully adapted to humans and can nest and feed on whatever humans provide. Since wild populations have been interbreeding with domestic pigeons for years, a large majority of Rock Pigeons seen around us are 'feral'.